No one is my enemy but myself
Woe is me! I have torn my garment with my own hands.

Badauni further mentioned an occasion in which, troubled, he asked Abu'l Fazl, about his need to argue about the various tenets of Islam: 'For which of these notorious heresies have you yourself the greatest inclination?' To which Abu'l Fazl smiled and replied nonchalantly, 'I wish to wander for a few days in the vale of infidelity for sport.' Abu'l Fazl then 'fell boldly into disputation in religious matters with such imbecile old men as the Sadr, the Qazi, the Hakim-ul Mulk and Makhdum-ul Mulk, and had not the slightest hesitation in putting them to shame, at which the Emperor was pleased'. So roundly humiliated were the theologians that they wrote to Abu'l Fazl privately, in bafflement: 'Why are you always falling foul of us?' Abu'l Fazl answered flippantly, implying that he was just sensing the winds of change and following them. And so the theologians, supposedly the highest upholders of Islamic law, were shown to be mediocre philosophers and base men. 'His Majesty was genuinely seeking after the Truth,' admitted Badauni but because of these discussions 'doubts had been planted in his mind so that within five or six years Islam had all but disappeared.'

Disappointed by the sheer number of contradictory traditions and decrees held as infallible by the different orthodox Sunni theologians, Akbar invited proponents of the other sects of Islam, such as the Shias and the Mahdavis* to the ibadat khana. But here again the men became irrevocably entrenched in their various beliefs, to the extent of abusing the others' cherished holy figures and heroes. Even the Prophet and his companions were not spared and the discussions once again descended into recriminations and accusations. In October 1578 Akbar finally decided to invite scholars and thinkers from outside the Islamic fold to join in the discussions. 'Sufi, philosopher, orator, jurist, Sunni, Shia, Brahman, Jati, Sevra (Jain monks), Charbak, Nazarene, Jew, Savi, Zoroastrian and others enjoyed exquisite pleasure,' wrote Abu'l Fazl, 'by beholding the calmness of the assembly… The treasures of secrets were opened out without fear of hostile seekers after battle.'

An early Christian visitor to the Mughal court was Father Julian Pereira, who arrived in March 1578 at Akbar's invitation. Described as 'a man of more virtue than learning' he exposed the errors of Islam during discussions with the ulema, causing the agitated Akbar to jump up during the talks with loud shouts of, 'May God help me!May God help me!', so annoyed and